



Best Blu-ray player

Even now, the Sony PlayStation 3 remains the best value-for-money option in Blu-ray products

Safe online

You can use dedicated internet-only credit cards such as HDFC NetSafe and ICICI 3D Secure for safe online payments

may know how to handle a disc, most of us have parents, siblings and friends who would hold a disc on the wrong side, keep it flat on a corrosive surface or try to clean it without knowing how to. That is a fair portion of the audience of these sites as well, so be prepared for some discs that you would want to get rid of as soon as you are done watching the movie. Thankfully, if you do get a damaged disc, all the three services will offer to exchange it for you, free of cost.

Buying online

MovieMart also doubles up as an online movie store with a collection of both Bollywood and Hollywood movies that finds little parallel on the net. Movies, TV shows, documentaries are available across various media, such as VCD, DVD and Blu-ray.

Navigating the site is quite a hassle, though. A lot of dead links, a clunky interface and a so-so search feature make this a browsing nightmare. But put up with all that and you are bound to get most of the titles you are looking for, and at pretty decent prices to boot.

Downloading / streaming

Broadband internet is starting to look better in India. Limited download plans of

up to 2 Mbps have been around for some time, but now, firms like Airtel and MTNL are making it viable for power users to buy 512 kbps and 1 Mbps tariff plans with unlimited download options. With such speeds and such capacity, the idea of moving to a non-disc method of media is always tempting.

However, while the iTunes store and NetFlix have availed American citizens of incredible ease in downloading and streaming their favourite movies and TV shows, it is not quite the same for us in India. There is still no viable option to download flicks or stream them, and most of the ways have grey legal areas.

1,300 free-to-watch movies, we really can't complain much. If you would prefer downloading movies on to your hard drive, we have not come across any such option as yet for Hindi movies.

For English movies, you could try out ZML (www.zml.com), which lets you download unlimited movies for a monthly rate of \$39.90 (Rs. 1,850 approximately). The price is a bit steep, but the site does offer high-quality movies in different formats. But be very careful when you're signing up. While ZML offers a trial period of one day for \$0.99 (Rs. 46), it will start charging your credit card automatically from the next day for the full amount of \$39.90, unless you cancel it yourself.

Conclusion

Renting is still the best option of the lot because of the large collections offered there while being extremely cost-effective. Even with an annual subscription to rent unlimited movies, you would not be spending more than Rs. 3,500. At the lowest rate of renting two DVDs a week, users would still be shelling out only Rs. 33 per disc, approximately. It should also be noted that BigFlix is the only service that offers the option of renting unlimited discs, so serious cinema-watchers might want to go in for that.

As for streaming and downloading movies, the Indian market is infantile at best. BigFlix is the only saving grace here, with no one offering services like NetFlix or Hulu yet. And as mentioned earlier, the free streaming movies on BigFlix have a limited catalogue and suffer greatly when it comes to quality of video. But as they say, beggars can't be choosers. **[4]**

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If you're not into watching movies online, you're probably renting DVDs or, ahem, getting them from elsewhere. Big hard drives seem to be the need of the day, but before you run out to get yourself one, you might like to know that we're going to be testing terabytes of storage in January.

TARIFF			
LOWEST	RATE	AT A TIME	LIMITATION
MOVIE MANTRA	Rs. 179 per transaction	2 discs	3 days time period
SEVENTYMM	Rs. 250 monthly charge	1 disc	5 discs in a month
BIGFLIX	Rs. 300 monthly charge	1 disc	7 discs in a month
HIGHEST	Rate	At a time	Limitation
MOVIE MANTRA	Rs. 3,499 per year	6 discs	96 discs in a year
SEVENTYMM	Rs. 3,499 per year	2 discs	96 discs in a year
BIGFLIX	Rs. 3,500 per year	1 disc	Unlimited discs

A better, and safer, option for streaming movies is to check out the free streaming catalogue offered by BigFlix. Of course, most of this is Hindi, but you do get quite a few gems in there.

Among new movies, you can stream

99 for free. Hindi movies such as *Bheja Fry* in addition to other popular movies are also available. All you have to do is select the movie you want to watch, ensure your internet connection is working and start streaming! On a 512 kbps connection, we could watch the movies without any lag. However, as expected, the quality left a lot to be desired. Still, with a catalogue of over



Movie Mart has a superb catalogue of movies to buy, be they VCD, DVD or Blu-ray